

AI Tools for Learning Design: What to Use and When™

Choose the right AI tool for the job, and build learning assets faster.

BUILT AROUND THE TOOL SELECTOR™: FOUR QUESTIONS THAT PICK THE RIGHT TOOL, EVERY TIME

Know which AI tool to use, and when, to create slides, videos, graphics, narration and learning assets without wasting hours comparing tools.

- ✓ The Trainerfy360 Tool Selector™: four questions that pick the tool
- ✓ The AI Tool-to-Task Matrix: the best tool for every common job
- ✓ The Trainerfy360™ Recommended Stack: what actually gets used
- ✓ AI-Enabled ADDIE: where tools fit in your project lifecycle
- ✓ Tool Scorecard: ease, speed & quality rated out of 5



27 Tasks

Mapped to a best-fit tool



16 Tools

Rated for ease, speed & quality



5 Stages

AI across all of ADDIE



1 Framework

The Tool Selector™

You don't need another AI tools list. You need a decision system.

Spending more time evaluating AI tools than building with them is a common trap. Hundreds of options, a new "Top 20" list every week, and deadlines that don't wait.

This guide is a **tool-to-task decision system**: which tool fits which job, and when to use each one.

How to use this guide.

This isn't a cover-to-cover read. Come in with a task and follow this path:

- 1 Map your project first** · Use the AI-Enabled ADDIE table to spot where AI will save you the most time in your current project. [Page 3](#)
- 2 Answer the four Selector questions** · What am I making, what's my input, how much time, how polished? They narrow any task to one or two tools. [Page 4](#)
- 3 Confirm your pick in the Matrix** · Find your task, check why the tool fits and what it's best for. Our recommended stack is there too. [Pages 5–6](#)
- 4 Copy a recipe** · Match your scenario, or follow the SME-notes-to-asset workflow step by step. [Pages 7–8](#)
- 5 Settle ties with the Scorecard** · When two tools both fit, compare ease, speed and output quality before you commit. [Page 9](#)

Before you start: if you work with sensitive or regulated data, check your organisation's AI and data policies before uploading SME notes or internal content to cloud-based tools.

AI-Enabled ADDIE: Where tools fit in your project.

Where AI creates leverage across the learning lifecycle

ADDIE is a widely used learning design process: Analyse, Design, Develop, Implement, Evaluate. Here is where AI can do the heavy lifting at each stage.

ADDIE STAGE	COMMON TASKS	AI TOOLS THAT HELP	BIGGEST TIME-SAVER
Analyse	Gather needs, clarify objectives, understand audience	ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Perplexity, NotebookLM	Upload SME docs and let AI extract themes, gaps and audience questions
Design	Structure content, outline activities, draft scripts	ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Canva	Draft outlines, learning objectives, and activity ideas in minutes
Develop	Build slides, videos, graphics, eLearning	Gamma, Rise, Storyline, HeyGen, Vyond, ElevenLabs, Canva, Descript	Build slides, video, audio, eLearning at 3-5× speed
Implement	Deploy through LMS, deliver workshops, share videos	LMS, 360Learning, video platforms, Camtasia	Auto-caption, transcript, distribute via LMS or video platform
Evaluate	Collect feedback, analyse results, iterate	ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, forms, survey tools, LMS analytics	Summarise feedback, suggest improvements, draft survey questions

The same tool can appear at several stages — ADDIE isn't a straight line. Choose by task, not by stage alone. This is a map, not a shackle.

The Trainerfy360 Tool Selector™

Four questions that choose the tool for you

Answer all four and the shortlist is usually one or two tools. Confirm the fit in the matrix on the next page.



1 · What am I making?

- Slides → Gamma, Canva or Claude (.pptx)
- Video → HeyGen, Synthesia or Vyond
- eLearning → Rise or Storyline
- Audio → ElevenLabs or Descript
- Images → Canva AI, Midjourney, DALL·E 3
- Documents & reports → Claude (.docx) or ChatGPT
- Surveys & evaluation forms → ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini



2 · What's my input?

- SME notes or documents → Claude, ChatGPT, NotebookLM
- Recorded footage → Descript, Camtasia
- A brief or outline → Gamma, Rise, HeyGen
- A prompt only → Midjourney, DALL·E 3, Vyond
- Survey results or feedback data → ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini
- Policy or compliance documents → NotebookLM, Claude



3 · How much time do I have?

- Under an hour → Gamma, HeyGen, ElevenLabs
- Half a day → Rise, Vyond, Descript
- A full build → Storyline, Camtasia
- Ongoing → Claude, ChatGPT, NotebookLM
- A recurring report or evaluation cycle → reusable prompts in Claude or ChatGPT



4 · How polished must it be?

- First draft or internal → Gamma, ChatGPT
- Client-ready and branded → Canva, Claude
- Publication-quality → Midjourney, Storyline, Camtasia
- Regulated or compliance content → AI drafts, SME sign-off

Why four questions? Tool choice fails when it starts with the tool. Start with the task, the input, the deadline and the finish, and the right tool selects itself. AI should support judgement, not replace it.

The AI Tool-to-Task Matrix.

For each task, here's the best tool and why.

TASK	RECOMMENDED TOOL	WHY IT FITS	BEST FOR
Create a workshop deck from scratch	Gamma	Fast structure, clean slides, minimal friction	<i>Quick decks, first drafts, time-crunch days</i>
Create a web-based course quickly	Rise (Articulate 360)	Fast authoring, responsive design, AI-assisted	<i>Mobile-friendly courses, quick rollouts</i>
Refine and brand existing slides	Canva	Magic Edit, brand kits, easy polish	<i>Making things look "done" without a designer</i>
Create a short explainer video (avatar)	HeyGen	AI avatars + script-to-video, fast turnaround	<i>Quick explainers, onboarding, simple concepts</i>
Create a personalised avatar of you	HeyGen	Best-in-class personalised avatar cloning	<i>Trainer-led content at scale, personal brand videos</i>
Create videos with stock avatars	Synthesia	Polished library of generic avatars	<i>Corporate training where any presenter works</i>
Create a short explainer video (animation)	Vyond	AI scripts, scenes, characters, animation	<i>Animated training, scenarios, storytelling</i>
Create illustrated characters and scenes	Vyond	Character builder, scene and prop libraries	<i>Scenario illustrations, character-led learning</i>
Create narration without hiring talent	ElevenLabs	Natural-sounding voice, voice cloning	<i>Voiceover without mic stress or studio time</i>
Edit video + add captions easily	Descript	Edit video by editing text, captions, overdub	<i>Fast video edits, captioning, quick fixes</i>
Create an infographic or job aid	Canva AI	Templates, Magic Edit, fast visuals	<i>Quick graphics that don't look generic</i>
Create motion graphics or animated photos	Canva AI	Magic Animate, animated text + photo effects	<i>Animated intros, social-style clips, slides with movement</i>
Build interactive eLearning	Storyline	Full control, scenarios, branching	<i>eLearning that feels real, not generic</i>
Run role plays and conversation practice	ChatGPT or Claude	Plays the other character, adapts, gives feedback	<i>Difficult conversations, coaching and feedback practice</i>
Create polished, branded imagery	Midjourney or DALL-E 3	Better quality, more style control	<i>Professional visuals, branded imagery</i>
Create quick concept images	ChatGPT	Fast concept art, quick visuals	<i>Brainstorming, rough concepts, placeholder art</i>
Record software training	Camtasia	Screen recording + editing in one tool	<i>Software demos, step-by-step training</i>

The AI Tool-to-Task Matrix (continued).

TASK	RECOMMENDED TOOL	WHY IT FITS	BEST FOR
Summarise SME notes into content	ChatGPT or Claude	Great at distilling, organising, drafting	<i>Turning messy input into usable content</i>
Research trends, tools, data	Perplexity or Gemini	Fast, cited answers, research-friendly	<i>Quick fact-checks, trend scans, background research</i>
Scan social commentary and live trends	Grok (xAI)	Real-time access to X posts and live discussion	<i>Social sentiment, emerging topics, what practitioners are saying</i>
Synthesise research, source docs, SME content	NotebookLM	Upload sources, ask questions, audio overviews	<i>Deep research synthesis, dense docs into usable content</i>
Draft scripts, outlines, and course copy	Claude (Anthropic)	Strong at long-form, nuanced writing and analysis	<i>Scripts, storyboards, outlines, learning content drafts</i>
Create an editable slide deck (.pptx)	Claude (pptx skill)	Generates editable PowerPoint files directly from notes or a brief	<i>Decks you'll finish in PowerPoint, branded templates</i>
Research, ideation, Google Workspace tasks	Gemini (Google)	Tight Google integration, multimodal, fast	<i>Teams in Google Workspace, research + drafting combined</i>
Draft and summarise inside Microsoft 365	Microsoft 365 Copilot	AI embedded in Word, PowerPoint, Teams and Outlook	<i>Meeting transcripts to action items, first-pass drafts in your own files</i>
Compare AI model outputs side by side	Multi (getmulti.ai)	Run any prompt across multiple models simultaneously	<i>Prompt testing, picking the best model for a task</i>
Collaborative course creation + LMS	360Learning	AI-assisted creation, collaborative LMS	<i>Teams that want creation + distribution together</i>

What's coming

Articulate has announced **AI avatar video generation for Articulate 360**, currently previewing through its Articulate Labs early-access program. If you build in Rise or Storyline, watch this space: avatars inside your authoring tool could simplify the whole video step. The bigger shift on the horizon is from tools to systems — agents and workflow builders (such as Copilot Studio) that turn one-off AI help into repeatable team processes.

New to AI? Start with ChatGPT or Claude, Canva and Gamma. Most designers get 80% of the productivity gain from those three alone.

Common L&D Scenarios: "I need..."

How the system looks in practice, when the clock is ticking

These are the exact scenarios we hear from instructional designers every week.

I NEED...	USE THIS	WHY
A workshop deck by tomorrow.	Gamma + Canva	Fast draft, then quick polish.
A three-minute compliance explainer.	Claude → HeyGen + ElevenLabs	Script first, then straight to avatar video and narration.
Scenario-based dialogue for role plays.	ChatGPT or Claude	Plays the other character, adapts, gives feedback.
An animated scenario story.	Vyond	Characters, scenes and storytelling without a studio.
Branching decision practice.	Storyline	Realistic choices with consequences, full control.
To prototype a course fast.	ChatGPT or Claude → Gamma → Storyline	Fast draft → quick structure → interactive prototype (full workflow: page 8).
To turn messy SME notes into something usable.	Claude or ChatGPT	Refining, not rewriting from scratch.
To record a software demo.	Camtasia	Industry standard for a reason.

COMMON AI TOOL MISTAKES

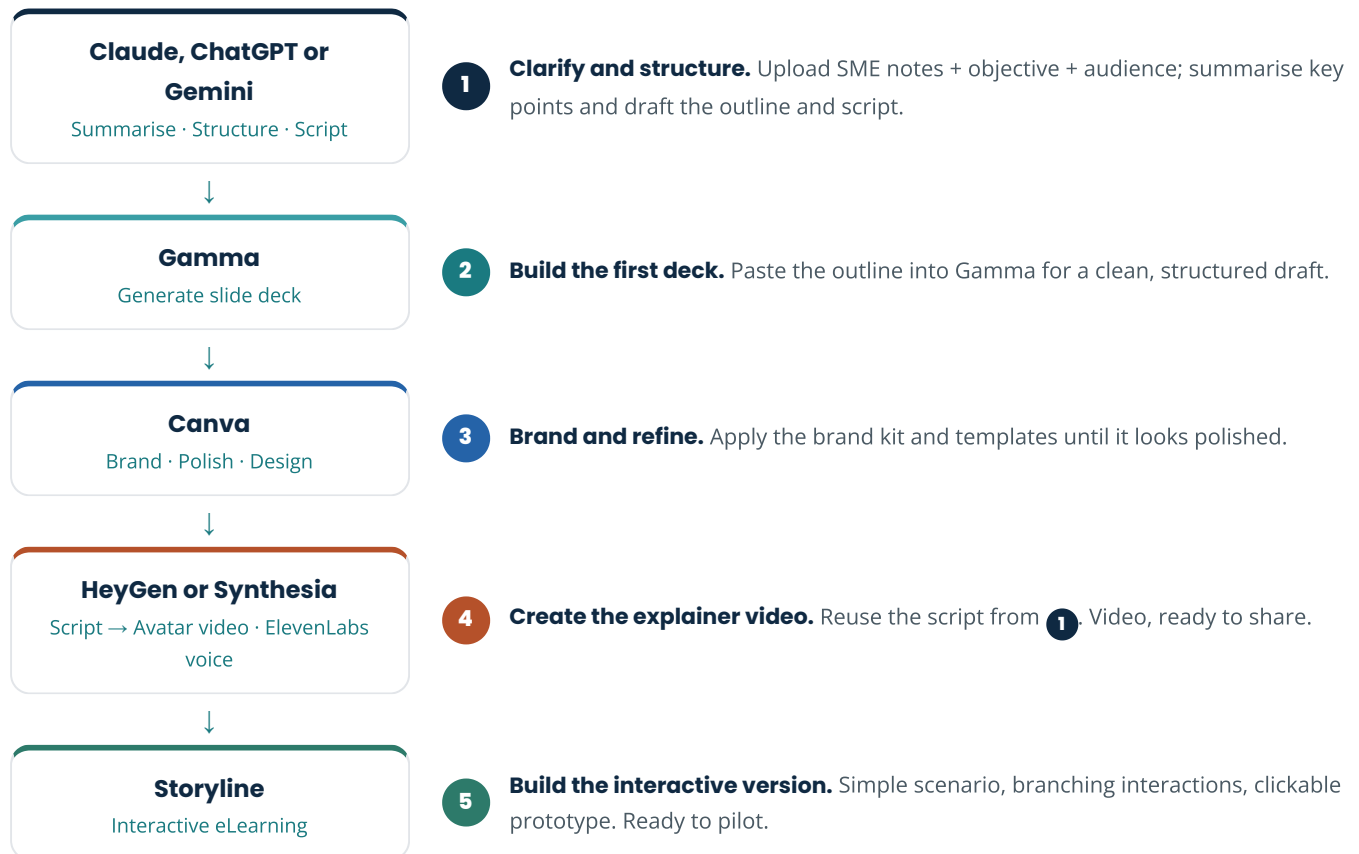
- Buying five tools before mastering one
- Using Storyline when Rise would do
- Creating videos before validating content
- Thinking better tools solve poor prompts

From SME Notes to Learning Asset in 30 Minutes.

What an experienced designer actually does

This is the bit you can't easily Google: a real workflow, from chaos to asset, with decisions and sequencing.

Input → SME notes (Word doc brain dump) · One learning objective · Audience: new managers · Deadline: end of week



Time → Roughly 30 minutes of focused work, if you're not starting from zero.

Working with internal or regulated content? Check your organisation's AI policy before step 1.

Tool Scorecard.

Ease · Speed · Output Quality · rated out of 5

A quick sanity check for when you're weighing up your options. These reflect real-world use, not marketing pages.

TOOL	EASE	SPEED	OUTPUT QUALITY	SWEET SPOT
Gamma	● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ○ ○	First drafts, structure & storyboarding, then polish in Canva
Canva / Canva AI	● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ○	● ● ● ● ● ●	Brand polish, graphics, job aids
HeyGen	● ● ● ● ● ○	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ○	Short explainer videos, best under 10 min; longer content can be costly and unstable
ElevenLabs	● ● ● ● ● ○	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ●	Natural narration, no mic needed
Descript	● ● ● ● ● ○	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ○	Video edits + captions quickly
Vyond	● ● ● ● ○ ○	● ● ● ● ● ○	● ● ● ● ● ○	Animated scenarios and storytelling
Storyline	● ● ○ ○ ○ ○	● ● ○ ○ ○ ○	● ● ● ● ● ●	Complex interactivity, full control
Rise	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ○	● ● ● ● ● ○	Fast responsive web courses
Camtasia	● ● ● ● ○ ○	● ● ● ● ○ ○	● ● ● ● ● ●	Screen recording + software demos
ChatGPT	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ●	The default L&D workhorse: outlines, objectives, scripts, scenarios, job aids
Claude	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ●	Long-form, nuanced content + analysis
Gemini	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ○	Google Workspace + fast research
Perplexity	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ○	Cited research, trend scans
NotebookLM	● ● ● ● ● ○	● ● ● ● ● ○	● ● ● ● ● ●	Deep synthesis from source docs
Multi	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ●	● ● ● ● ● ●	Compare models, pick the best output
Midjourney	● ● ● ● ○ ○	● ● ● ● ○ ○	● ● ● ● ● ●	High-quality professional imagery

5/5 = best in class · 2/5 = works, but expect friction. Ratings reflect real-world instructional design use, not vendor feature lists.

Quick selection rules.

The whole guide, condensed. This is the page to pin.

WHEN YOU NEED...	RECOMMENDED...	WHY
Speed and structure	Gamma	Fastest path from outline to deck
Web course, mobile-friendly	Rise (Articulate 360)	Quick authoring, responsive design
Brand polish	Canva	Easy branding, polished visuals
Quick avatar video	HeyGen	Script-to-video, no filming
Quality narration	ElevenLabs	Natural voices, zero recording setup

Want to go deeper?

You don't need to be an AI expert. You just need a better system.



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I've spent more than 20 years designing learning across corporate, government and higher education.

When AI arrived, I saw talented instructional designers facing a new challenge: not learning the technology, but figuring out how to use it without sacrificing quality, judgement and good learning design.

That's why I created resources like this guide and the **C.R.A.F.T.™ Framework**, practical systems to help L&D professionals work smarter with AI, without losing what makes great learning design great.



20+

Years in Learning Design



2

Industry Awards



C.R.A.F.T.™

Framework Creator

Want the prompts behind the workflow?

The **C.R.A.F.T.™ AI Prompt Toolkit for L&D Professionals** shows you how to use these tools well.

- Proven frameworks for writing better prompts
- Prompts for slides, scripts, graphics, and learning content
- A repeatable system for getting better outputs from AI

Download the **C.R.A.F.T.™ AI Prompt Toolkit** · trainerfy360.com/craft

Want the full system?

The **AI-Enabled ADDIE Playbook™** brings the method, the tools and the workflows together.

- The AI-Enabled ADDIE Model™: the complete method, Analyse to Evaluate
- Build workflows: scenarios, simulations, AI video and eLearning
- Templates, the full C.R.A.F.T. method and a 30-day action plan

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